

WINNING ROUND ONE



SIPRA DAS



SUMET INDUR SINGH

AP PHOTOGRINDER OSAN

THE LEFT'S PRESSURE TACTICS HAVE WORKED, RESULTING

■ **By Satarupa Bhattacharjya**

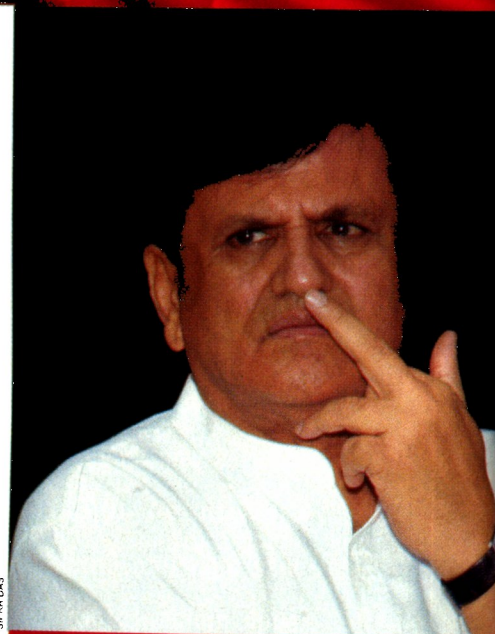
In the end, it was the Congress Party which blinked. In a significant climbdown from Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's earlier stand on the nuclear deal with the US, External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, the key negotiator with the Left, announced that the "operationa-lising" of the Indo-US nuclear agree-ment would be put on hold pending the findings of the committee set up to look into the objections raised by the Left parties. While no time frame was men-tioned in Mukherjee's statement, it proves a moral victory for the Left and something of an embarrassment for the Congress which had taken a tough line over the last few weeks through its spin doctors.

Left leaders had earlier put the Congress in a spot by demanding a public statement on the future of the agreement. The stalemate, despite Mukherjee's statement, remains. "Any announcement must be accompanied by a commitment that the Government will not proceed with operationalising the deal till the committee comes out with its findings," CPI(M) Politburo member Sitaram Yechury had said

after a meeting of the Front. When asked to define operationalisation, Yechury's Politburo colleague M.K. Pandhe explained, "To us operational-ising means entering the next stage of the agreement; talking to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) for India-specific safeguards."

Earlier, Mukherjee had assured the Left leaders that their objections to the Henry Hyde Act (2006)—the coopera-tion agreement—on the ground that it is bound by certain sections of the US domestic law, would be addressed in the joint panel. The Left, however, seemed to be aware of former foreign secretary Shyam Saran's recent visits to Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) mem-ber states Argentina, Brazil, Germany and Russia. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh had sent Saran as his special envoy to negotiate nuclear fuel supply with governments of those four nations while Mukherjee was firefighting back home. The Government has been furthering the agreement via informal talks with the NSG. The Left had there-fore sought an official "pause".

Indications that the Congress could not afford to ignore the Left's opposition



SIPRA DAS

THE CONGRESS TEAM'S

to the agreement came last weekend when Sonia Gandhi cut short her South Africa visit and returned to the Capital. Sonia and Manmohan Singh had since discussed consequences of the impasse on their party and the Government. The UPA Government was pushed to the